



*Simulated engagement during Brazen Chariots

and the newly-acquired Smerch rockets rained a devastating salvo of rockets 90 km away, each weighing nearly a tonne. All lines of enemy defences were attacked simultaneously in day and night operations. In three days, aircraft and artillery had smothered targets with 450 tonne of ordnance, clearing the field for the tanks and infantry combat vehicles to move in and capture the smoking battle ground. "At the end of the destruction," Kamat concluded wryly, "there is nothing left for us to occupy."

This shock and awe scenario recently played out in the desert was the army's sixth major wargame since it unveiled its new strategy in 2004. The Pakistani military attaché was not invited to the display which took place before 103 observers from 59 countries. Held just 30 km from the nuclear test site, the exercises were another test of

the world's only doctrine which envisages fighting a limited war under the nuclear overhang. It changes the army's mindset from that of carrying out a defensive operation to an outrightly offensive one and refocuses the aim of a future conventional conflict from destroying the enemy's war machine to destroying his will to fight.

The idea of swift manoeuvre operations is as old as Sun Tzu and, first implemented by the Germans during the Second World War as the Blitzkrieg, is new to the Indian Army. During the two week-long 1971 War, it had marched 4 km into Pakistani territory. The new doctrine was born out of the failure of military mobilisation during Operation Parakram in 2002 and Pakistan exploiting a nuclearised environment to continue a proxy war. It aims to deter Pakistan from escalating its proxy war—either through assassinations of

important political leaders or mass casualty attacks.

The army has two types of corps (a concentration of nearly one lakh troops) operating on a sword and shield principle. Ten holding corps are tasked with defending territory, and three are strike corps or swords—tasked with offensive operations into enemy territory. In the army's old doctrine, the holding formation would be first deployed on the border and would then wait for the strike corps to arrive from their bases several hundred kilometres in the hinterland. Under the new doctrine, the shields, or the holding formation, will be mobilised within 72 hours. They will attack the enemy without waiting for the arrival of the strike corps. The attack can occur anywhere along the international boundary and at a place and time of its choosing. In the past four years, the army has tinkered with var-

"TECHNOLOGY HAS ENABLED US TO REDUCE THE NUMBER OF SOLDIERS FOR AN ATTACK."

LT-GEN N. THAMBURAJ, GOC-IN-C SOUTHERN COMMAND